

HIGH SCHOOL BOYS BASKETBALL: DISTRICT FINALS

Cardinals hold on for emotional win over Tarblooders

By TIM WARSINSKEY

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

There are no guarantees when teenage boys compete and championships are at stake. So many high school games are ordinary and quickly forgotten. But there are rare occasions when young talent, character and raw emotion combine to create a memorable game amid unforgettable circumstances.

What more than 2,700 people jammed into Euclid's Harold Daugherty Gymnasium witnessed last night was a memory worth preserving.

Mentor's 83-82 overtime victory against Glenville in a Division I district final produced such joy for the triumphant Cardinals and heartache for the Tarblooders that it was as if two rivers of emotion flowed in opposite direc-

DIVISION I	
MENTOR	83
GLENVILLE	82

tions on the level basketball court.

When time expired after 36 tense minutes, Mentor players, coaches and fans stormed the floor. Coach Bob Krizancic leaped high into the air, for once spilling his trademark cup of water.

"This is the greatest feeling I've ever had in my life," said Mentor senior Rick Martucci. "It's so fulfilling because we have worked so hard for three years to get here."

Mentor, with its second district title in five seasons, is hoping to win at least two more games and earn its first state tournament berth. The Cardinals (21-3) play Stow (19-5) in a regional semi-

final Wednesday at the University of Akron's James Rhodes Arena.

"We've got something going here," Mentor senior Jason Bratten said. "It's set up for us. The state tournament is right in front of us and all we have to do is take advantage of it."

For many of the Tarblooders, the loss meant there would be no more basketball to heal their hurt after losing their coach, James O'Neal Johnson, who died of a heart attack five weeks ago. Despite a superb performance in which their team led most of the game, interim coach Gretchen Taylor could not hide the disappointment she felt.

"When you put your heart and soul in something, when you have a mission and the mission wasn't completed, you feel like a failure," Taylor said. "It wasn't be-

cause we didn't play hard or we didn't have community support."

As she spoke, Johnson's widow, LaDonna Winston Johnson, emerged from the locker room clutching the silver and walnut runner-up trophy. Tears welled in Taylor's eyes.

"I can see Coach J," she said. "I can see him saying we gave it our best shot. I see him wrapping his arms around me right now and saying, 'It's OK. Keep your head up.'"

The one player who gave Glenville (18-4) its shot was senior Aaron Nichols. He scored a career-high 37 points, including 22 points in the final nine minutes of the fourth quarter and overtime. He finished with five 3-pointers and set up teammate Eric Smith (16 points) on his four thunderous dunks.

Taylor used one word to describe Nichols' performance:

"Supercalifragilisticexpialidocious," she said, quoting from the movie "Mary Poppins."

Nichols, a 6-2 guard, pinned Mentor's ears back with three 3-pointers in the first quarter as Glenville rushed to a 17-7 lead. Glenville used his scoring and the trio of 6-6 forwards Smith, Pierre Woods and Michael Hearn to keep Mentor at bay.

The third and fourth quarters "were like a boxing match," Krizancic said. After Mentor took its first lead, 45-44, the largest margin the rest of the game was four points as they exchanged leads like jabs. Nichols scored 10 points in the final five minutes of the fourth quarter. He tied it, 70-70, when he rebounded his own miss and scored with 1:20 remaining.

After a Mentor turnover, Smith,

drove and scored, but the basket was nullified by a charging call with 58 seconds left. Mentor chose to wind the clock down and take the last shot, but Boyle missed a contested 3-pointer.

Overtime was no different, with three ties and two more lead exchanges. Martucci's layup with 26 seconds left gave the Cardinals an 81-79 lead. Nichols then drove the other end, but his shot went in and six and a teammate was called for fouling on the rebound. Mentor senior Jason Crowe, who had missed three of four foul shots, then sank two free throws with 11 seconds remaining.

Nichols hit a 3-pointer with five seconds left, but it was not enough.

E-mail: twarsinskey@plained.com
Phone: 440-602-4764

Tigers stop Preppers

Brooks sinks game-winner at the buzzer

By DICK ZUNT

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Finding the words to describe last night's game between Warrensville Heights and University School is difficult. Maybe the best word is "wow."

Warrensville got a tension-packed 71-69 overtime victory in Solon in the Division II district championship game, won at the buzzer by senior guard J.K. Brooks.

Brooks, a 5-10 senior guard, took an inbound pass and dribbled toward the basket, shooting the ball from inside the key with about two seconds remaining in the extra session and the game tied, 69-69.

The ball took its time, bouncing about four times before slipping through the net with no time showing on the clock.

"I just stood there watching the ball bounce four or five times," said Brooks. "As soon as the ball went in, I took off running down the court. I don't know why, I just ran."

DIVISION II	
WARRENSVILLE HEIGHTS	71
UNIVERSITY SCHOOL	69

The decisive basket brought happy Tigers fans onto the court in droves. Meanwhile, the Preppers and their fans were left stunned and exhausted.

Brooks finished with 29 points, including three big-time 3-point field goals that brought the Tigers back into the game late in the first quarter.

With University School leading, 11-2, with 3:15 remaining in the first quarter, Brooks sank 3-pointers at 3:03, 2:20 and 1:55 to tie the game.

University led, 13-12 at the end of the first quarter. Brooks tied the game at 17-17 with a 3-pointer at 5:46 of the second and tied it again, 22-22, on a driving layup with 4:08 left.

But his biggest basket was his last, giving the Tigers their 22nd win in 23 games.

"I wasn't really getting good looks at the basket all night, but I was taking the shots," said Brooks. "When the ball was bouncing on my last shot, I kept thinking, 'Please go in, please go



CHUCK CROW / THE PLAIN DEALER

Warrensville Heights' J.K. Brooks whoops it up after sinking the winning basket in overtime to defeat University School and send the Tigers to the regionals.

in."

"I did not want to go home," said Brooks. "I'm a starter as a senior and I can't let my players down. Big time players have to make big plays."

"J. K. has been our go-to guy all year," said Warrensville coach Dennis Chimes. "Everybody came to play, including our bench, which got quite a few minutes after some of our players got into foul trouble."

Sophomore Demetrius "Meche" Johnson fouled out with 2:56 left in the fourth quarter. Senior Brian Swift fouled out with 2:13 left in the overtime.

Johnson scored 13 points and Swift had 11, eight of them in the fourth quarter and overtime.

A three-point play by the Preppers' Logan White, a 6-4 junior, gave his team a 44-42 lead heading into the fourth quarter. White led University with 26 points, including 14 of 20 free throws.

Senior Tucker Kain had 14 points, junior Marques Torbert had 12 and senior Brooks Brown had 11 for the Preppers.

"(University) is a talented team," said Chimes.

"US played a heck of a game, right down to the wire," said Warrensville senior guard Richard

Yancy. "They played great games against us the past three years. This was a total team victory, right down to the bench."

"I'm grateful to God that we are able to continue our tournament play down to Canton."

The two best teams in Northeast Ohio matched up," said University School coach Tony Tucker, whose team ended with the best record in school history at 20-3. "They were a bounce of the ball better. I'm proud of our team. Warrensville brought everything to the game."

E-mail: dzunt@plained.com
Phone: 216-999-4748



CHUCK CROW / THE PLAIN DEALER

Warrensville Heights guard Rich Yancy, left, defends against University Heights guard Logan White last night.

"I prayed because I didn't want the game to go any longer," Brooks said.

And finally, the ball bounced through the nets after the final buzzer.

"It wasn't the shot that hurts so much, it's that we played so hard and we lost on a lucky bounce," said Logan White, who led the Preppers with 26 points. "It's a disappointing way to end our season."

But not for the Tigers.

"In a matter of minutes, I went from tears of sadness to tears of joy," Swift said. "I'm so proud of my teammates, especially because when I transferred here, everyone talked about this being my team. It's not my team. I'm just another piece to what we're trying to do here. I mean, I didn't play one of my better games, and I wasn't even in the game at the end and we won."

E-mail: twright@plained.com
Phone: 216-999-6136

Tigers oust Raiders as streak reaches 10

By EDDIE DWYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

While most of his teammates were taking part in the post-game celebration, Cleveland Heights senior forward James Lewis wanted to make one thing clear.

"Our work isn't done," Lewis said. "Yeah, this is a dream come true for most players. But I won't be satisfied until we're cutting down the nets in Columbus."

If Lewis and the rest of Tigers continue to play like they have for the last six weeks, a trip up the ladder in Ohio State's Value City Arena could become a reality.

Yesterday, Cleveland Heights continued to hold the hot hand as it eliminated longtime rival Shaker Heights, 75-64, in the Division I boys basketball district championship game at Cleveland South.

The Tigers, who extended their winning streak to 10 games, will take a 17-6 record into Thursday night's regional semifinal at the University of Akron. Cleveland Heights, the Division I state champion in 1997, will face Massillon Jackson at 7 p.m. in JAR Arena.

"We battled adversity, with kids being ineligible and people being down on us," said Tigers veteran coach Jim Cappelletti as tears rolled down his face. "Maybe we're not as great as those state-ranked teams. But one thing I know for sure. There is no team in the state that has more heart than these guys."

Cappelletti, who guided Cleveland Heights to five district titles and four state Final Four appearances during the last decade, saw that he'd come to the fore time and again yesterday.

With Lewis tipping in shots and all-district senior forward Aaron Nixon going strong to the basket, the Tigers led, 16-9, after the first eight minutes.

Shaker Heights (15-8), which

DIVISION I	
CLEVELAND HEIGHTS	75
SHAKER HEIGHTS	64

split two close Lake Erie League matchups with Cleveland Heights this season, missed several shots from close range in the early going. After Lewis tipped in another shot and hit two free throws, the Raiders trailed, 23-11, with 5:23 left in the first half.

A 3-pointer by Shaker Heights forward Jameson Evans cut the deficit to 23-16. But Cleveland Heights responded with layups by Nixon and center Andre Glenn, and rode Nixon's 13 first-half points to a 32-22 lead at the break. Nixon finished with a game-high 27 points, five more than Shaker Heights' all-district, junior forward Darrell White.

"We tried to make them take tough shots and beat us at the foul line," said Lewis, who scored 19 points. "We played like a team, helping each other out on defense. And you saw the results."

On the strength of two 3-pointers by junior guard Noah Williams, Shaker Heights closed to 36-30 with 5:40 remaining in the third quarter. The Tigers refused to fold, however, as they answered with a layup by Lewis off an assist from center Barry Coffield and a putback by Coffield. After Coffield converted an assist from Lewis into an easy layup, Cleveland Heights led, 46-35, with 1:41 left in the third quarter.

"The better team won, the young men who played more like a team," said Bob Wanson, who coached Shaker Heights to a Division I state runner-up finish in 1999. "I thought we came out and tried to play like individuals, and that's my fault. I wish I could have coached this team better. We had more talent than our record indicates."

E-mail: edwyer@plained.com
Phone: 216-999-4677

Win gives Bulldogs measure of revenge

By BOB MIGRA

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Mike Gansey and his Olmsted Falls teammates had almost exactly one year to think about last season's Division II district championship basketball game against Avon Lake.

"It seems like that's all I did was think about that game," Gansey said after last night's rematch with the Shoremen at Admiral King. "It was always in the back of my mind. I even watched the tape of last year's game this week. It made me want to play that much harder."

The extra effort showed, as the Bulldogs erased last season's disappointment with a 64-47 victory.

Olmsted Falls, which split the regular-season series with the Shoremen, played a nearly flawless second half.

It was the opposite of last season's championship, when the Shoremen went on a 20-0 run in the second half and Gansey went down with a knee injury in Avon Lake's 57-47 victory.

Olmsted Falls (19-4) advanced to Wednesday's regional semifinal at Cleveland State University against Tallmadge.

"I'm excited," said Gansey, who led all scorers with 30 points. "This feels great. It's unbelievable."

Gansey probably was not feeling the same way in the first quarter, when he went scoreless as Avon Lake jumped out to a 13-7 lead.

"I was pretty happy with the way we went out and played in the first quarter," Avon Lake coach Dave Olinger said. "That was the tempo we wanted. We wanted a lower-scoring game. We did an excellent job rebounding and holding them to one shot."

Tom Port, who finished with 17 rebounds, had seven in the first

DIVISION II	
OLMSTED FALLS	64
AVON LAKE	47

quarter. Port led Avon Lake with 21 points and Brian Ingelright scored 13.

But the Shoremen (19-4) could not contain the Bulldogs for long.

In the second quarter, Olmsted Falls guard Garry Reitler (11 points) hit consecutive 3-point goals to tie the game at 15-15. Then Gansey scored his team's last 10 points of the quarter. Gansey followed a missed shot by Adam Ancuri at the buzzer to give Olmsted Falls a 25-24 lead at the half.

"I told the kids at halftime we had to be grateful to be up by a point," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "We just weren't attacking them, and that was a lot of what they were doing to us. But Garry Reitler came up with some big threes for us and Mike continued to play his normal Mike game."

The Bulldogs started to pull away in the third quarter. After Armando Flores (10 points) started the scoring with a jump shot, Gansey scored another eight points to give Olmsted Falls a 37-32 lead.

"After the first quarter, we really didn't get into our offense very well," Olinger said. "Sometimes we have a tendency to stand around a little more than we should. In the second half, their pressure bothered us a little bit, and it just snowballed from there."

In the fourth quarter, Olmsted Falls handled Avon Lake's frantic full-court press to perfection. The Bulldogs made all five of their field-goal attempts and 15 of 21 foul shots to blow the game open.

E-mail: bmigra@plained.com
Phone: 800-767-2821

Warrensville Heights turns tears to cheers

By BRANSON WRIGHT

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Emotions wrapped its arms around Brian Swift lighter than a three-sizes-too-small sweater when he fouled out early in overtime. Swift couldn't escape its grip. The tears puddled in his eyes.

"My heart just dropped when I fouled out," said Swift, of Warrensville Heights. "All I could do was cry. I didn't want to end my high school career on the bench. But my teammates told me to keep my head up because they were going to come through."

And they did.

Swift, one of the top point guards in the state, had his prep career extended behind J.K. Brooks' winning shot with two seconds left to give Warrensville Heights a 71-69 overtime victory over University School in a classic affair last night during the Division II district finals at Solon High School.

Warrensville Heights, the defending state champions, advanced to the regional semifinals in Canton next week. That will give Swift another chance to come off the bench.

"That would've been so disappointing to end my career by fouling out," said Swift, who won a state title with St. Peter Chanel as a sophomore. "My teammates came together in the best district championship ever played in this area. You had two quality teams who played to the finish."

Swift, who scored eight of his 11 points in the second half, can thank Brooks for continuing the season. But kudos must first go to Roderick Wilson, who gave the Tigers a three-point lead with 44 seconds left in overtime. Dan Morrissey came down and nailed a trey to tie the score at 69. Brooks took the inbound and dribbled to the right side of the court. At about four seconds, he shook a defender and made his move inside the paint where he released the shot.

The ball bounced. "I just jumped up and prayed for the ball to go in," Swift said. And bounced.

"It seemed like it was staying up there forever," Tigers forward Tony Worrell said. "I started thinking that it was going to fall out."

And bounced.